Chapter 1 - The storm and the plan (0:00)

In 1900, a hurricane drowned Galveston, Texas, and killed at least six thousand people. A board of three engineers was asked how to stop it happening again. So they built a concrete seawall, seventeen feet high, with a curve to throw waves back up.

Chapter 2 - The town has to rise (0:18)

But a wall was not enough, because the town behind it still sat low. Then they decided to raise the town itself, about five hundred blocks, by up to seventeen feet. Whole streets stood on stilts, and people crossed town on wooden walkways high in the air.

Chapter 3 - Lifted by hand (0:37)

You see, the lifting was done by hand. Workers turned jackscrews, hundreds under one church alone. Dredges dug a canal and pumped in sand from the bay, over fifteen million cubic yards. So the sand rose, the town rose with it, and by 1910 the work was nearly done. In 1915 another huge hurricane hit, and this time Galveston survived.